Chapter 6.0

Geopolitics



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Session Outlines

- Introduction to Geopolitics
- Definition of Geopolitics
- Geography and Politics
- Cold War
- Types of Power in Geopolitics



Learning Objectives

After Completing this Session you have to:-

- Define Geopolitics
- Explain the meaning of Cold War
- Describe the Types of Power in Geopolitics



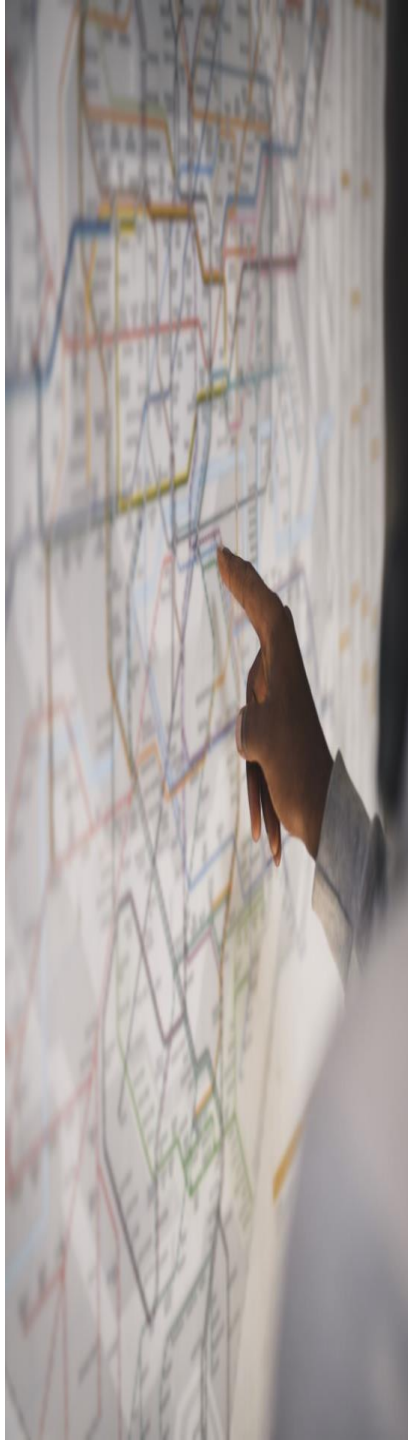






Introduction to geopolitics

Geopolitics is part of **human geography**. We can use the perspective of human geography to understand **how politics**, especially **international politics**, and **geography** are related.

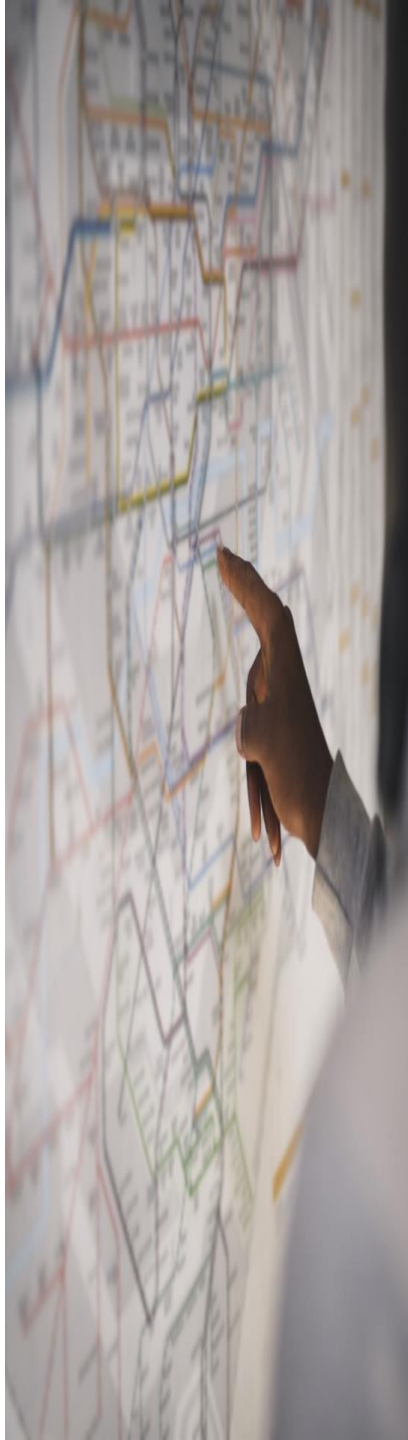


Introduction to geopolitics

A political geographer may study **elections** or **wars** whereas a **political scientist** or **scholar of international relations** argues that full understanding is only available from a **geographic perspective**.

The concepts of **place**, **space**, **scale**, **region**, **territory**, and **network** will be used to explore geopolitics.

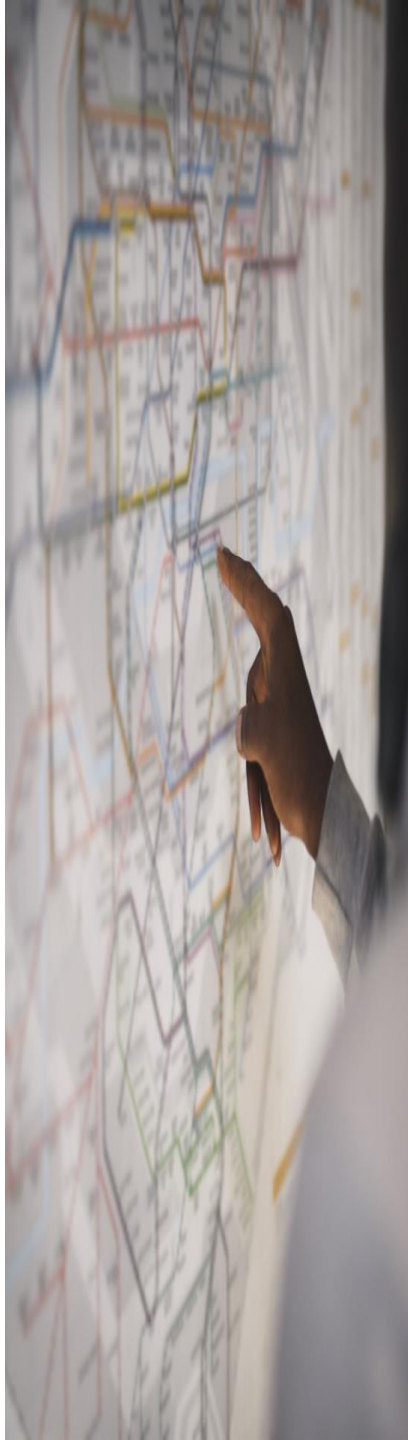
The concepts provide understandings into the **interaction** between **power relations** and **geography**.



Introduction to geopolitics

Nationalist movements want to change the **boundaries** on the **world political map** by making a **new geographic entity** a **new nation-state**.

If the **movement for Scottish national independence is successful**, there will be a new international border between a new country (**Scotland**) and a geographically diminished **Great Britain**.

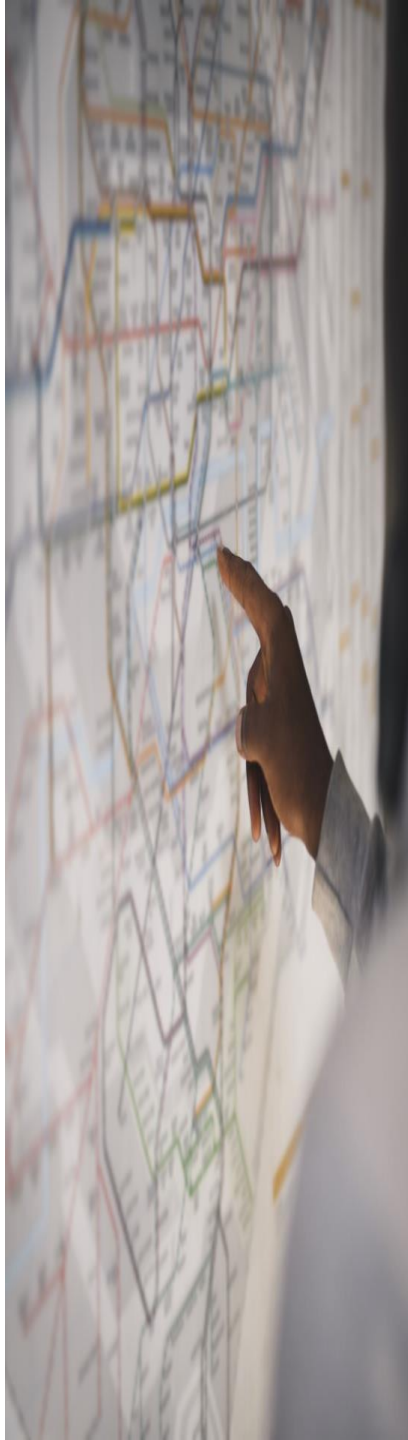


Introduction to geopolitics

Is political geography different from geopolitics?
Good question and there is **no easy** or clear answer.

Geopolitics is a form of **political geography** they both consider the **mutual construction** of geography and **politics**.

Political geography was originally about **domestic politics** such as **elections** or **strikes**.

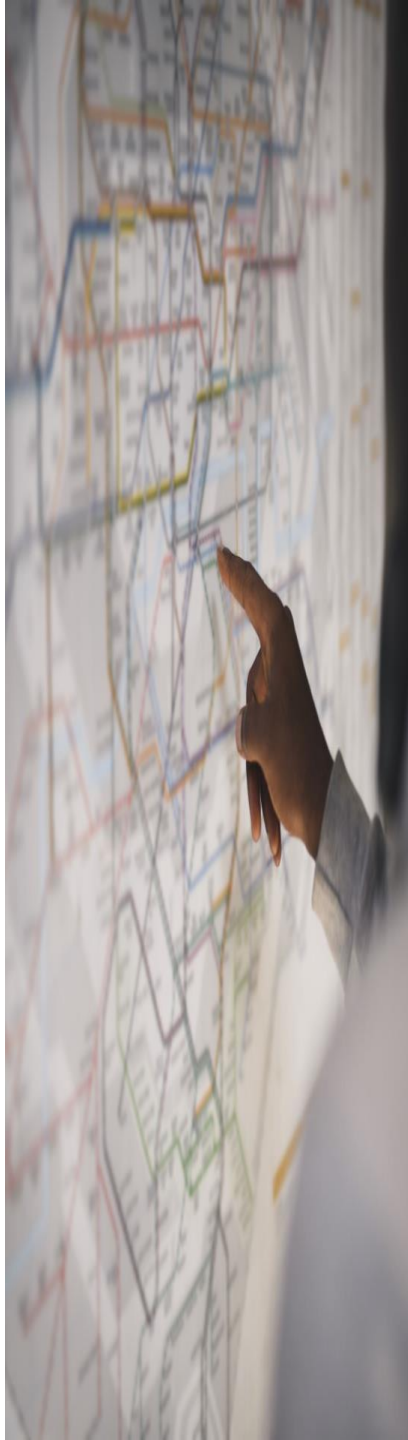


Introduction to geopolitics

Geopolitics was about **competition** and **conflict** between **states** and could be seen as a sub-set of **political geography**.

Geopolitics, as thought and practice, is linked to the establishment of states and nations as the dominant political institutions.

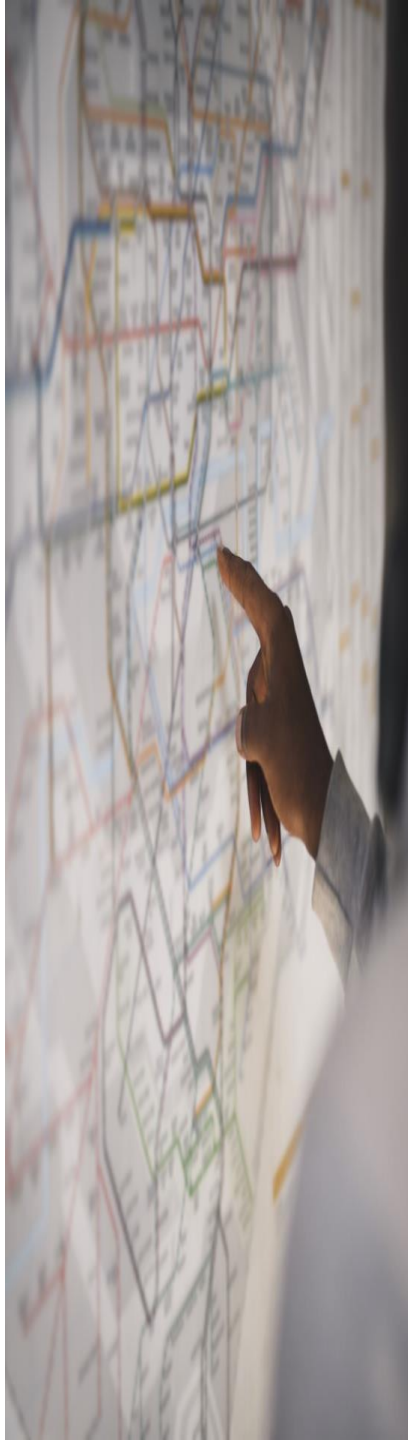
Geopolitics is connected to the end of the nineteenth century a period of increasing competition between the most powerful states.



What is geopolitics?

Geopolitics is the **struggle over the control of geographical entities** with an **international** and **global dimension**, and the **use of such geographical entities for political advantage**. This definition of geopolitics is in **two ways:-**

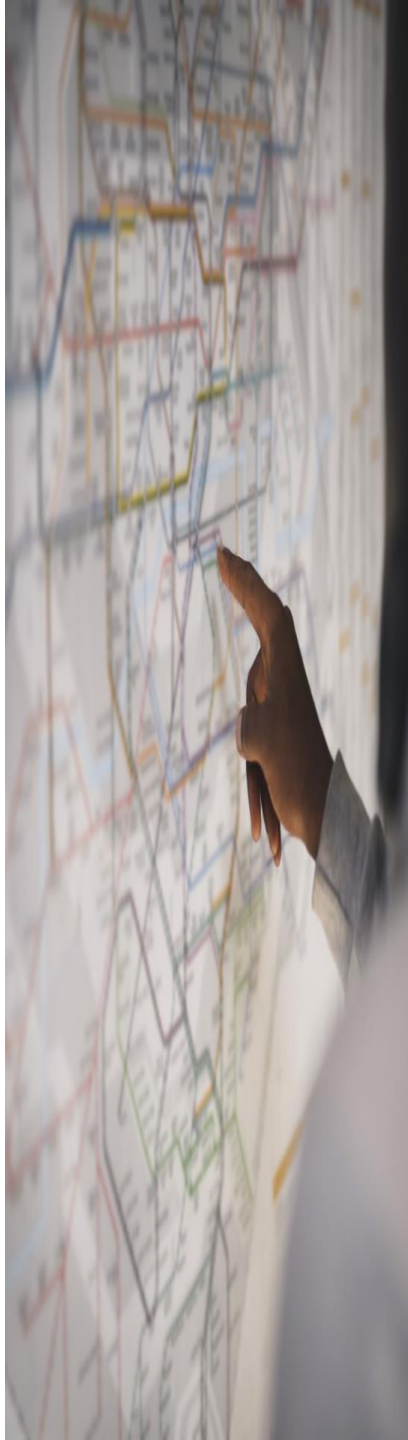
Geopolitics is to emphasize both **practice** and **representation**: In **everyday language**, **geopolitics involves actions** and **decisions** (**the declaration of war by a state**) and the way that the **action is explained** in the **media** and **political statements**.



What is geopolitics?

The second step is to **explore who has the power to act** by **undertaking geopolitical practices** and **making geopolitical representations**.

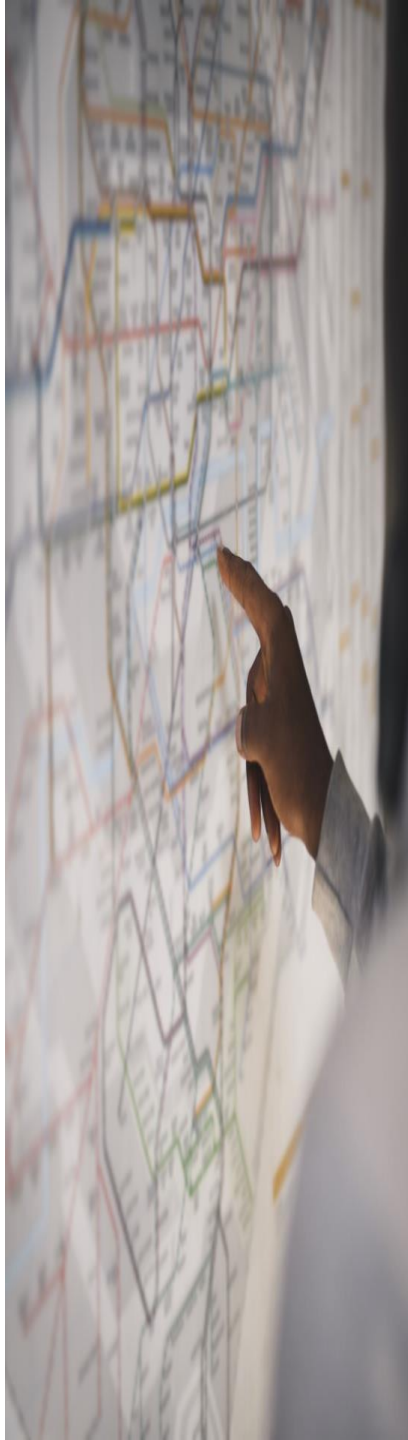
For instance, **European Union** and the **North Atlantic Treaty Organization** (**NATO**), include former **Soviet satellite states** such as **Poland** and the **Baltic states**. (**Estonia**, **Latvia**, and **Lithuania**)



Geography and politics

Human geography may be defined as the systematic study of what makes places unique and the connections and interactions between places.

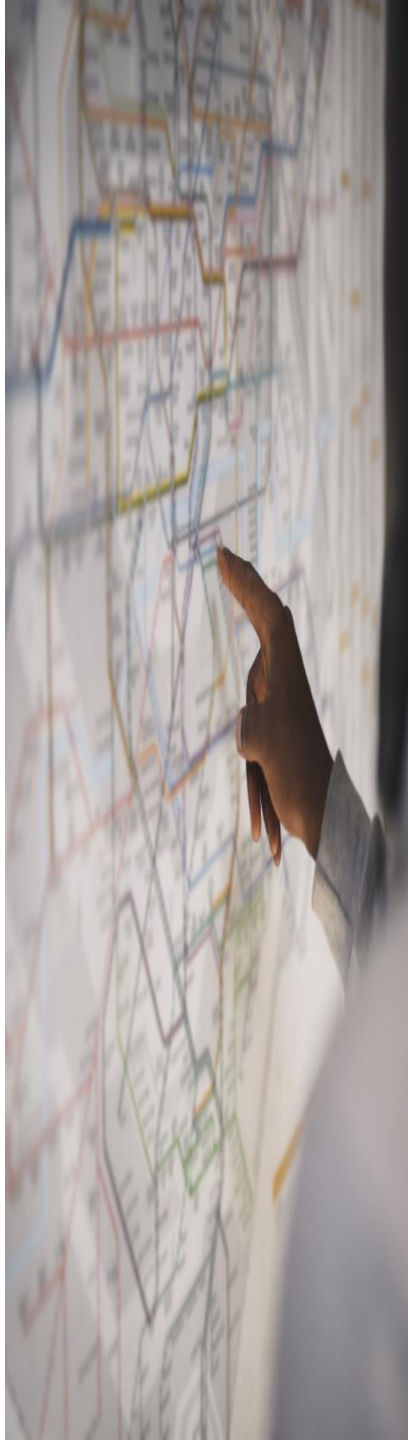
In this definition, human geographers are seen to focus on the study of particular neighbourhoods, towns, cities, or countries (the meaning of place being broad here). Geographers are people who study the specifics of the world.



Geography and politics

However, **places** (whether **neighbourhoods** or **countries**) are **not viewed as isolated units** that can only be understood through **what happens within them**.

The first definition also highlights the need to understand **places** in **relation** to the **rest of the world**.



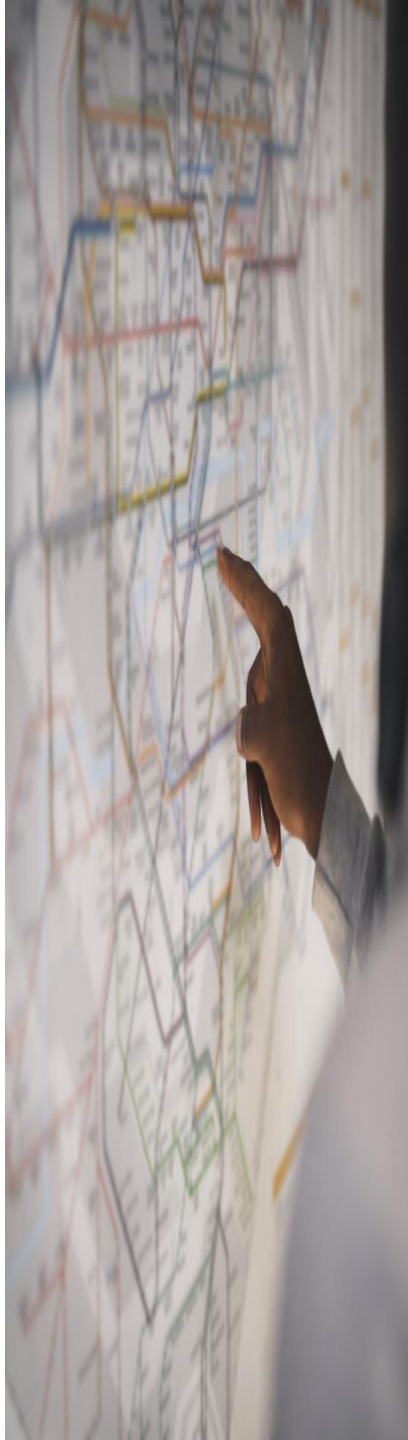
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Cold War as Geopolitics

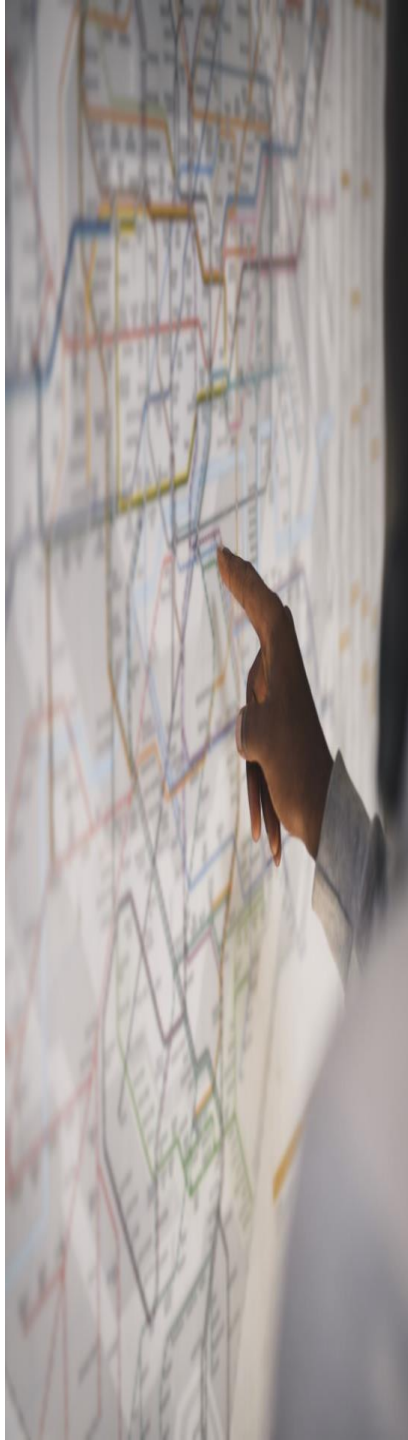
The **legacy** of the **Cold War remains** as **President Putin of Russia decries Western expansion eastwards**, and **Western leaders**, in the wake of the **conflict in Ukraine**, argue that **NATO** must defend against the potential of similar actions in the **Baltic states**.

The **Korean War** and the **Vietnam War** were seen, in the West, as part of a **global struggle** that was necessary to **limit Communist expansion**.



Cold War as Geopolitics

The **Cold War** involved many **geopolitical practices** by both the **United States** and the **Soviet Union** by creating a system of **allies** and **satellite states** in the **regionalization** of **Europe** and establishing **global networks of military bases**.



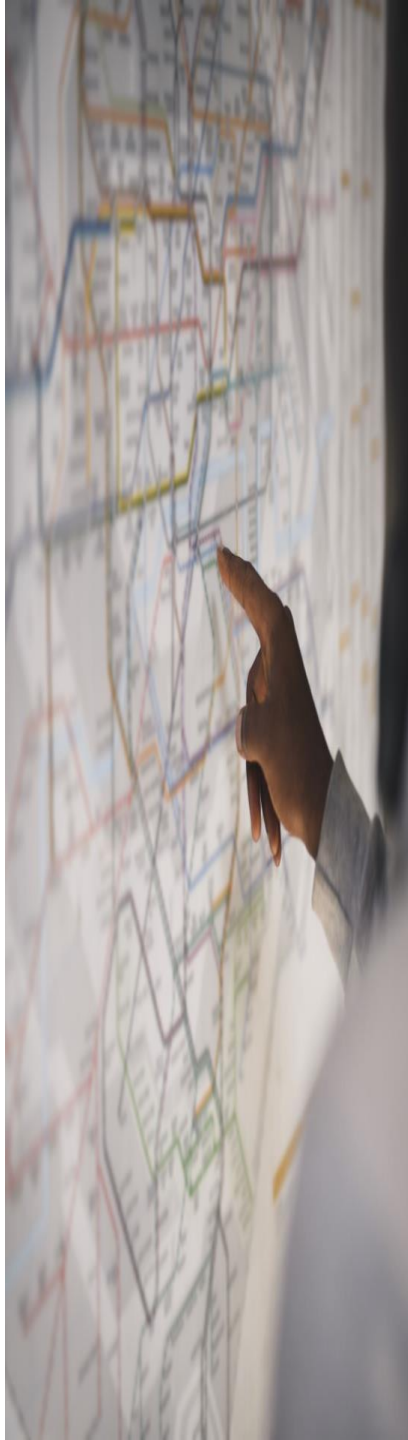
Types of power in Geopolitics

The **struggle over the control of geographic entities** is the use of **three different**, **but connected**, forms of power:

Material

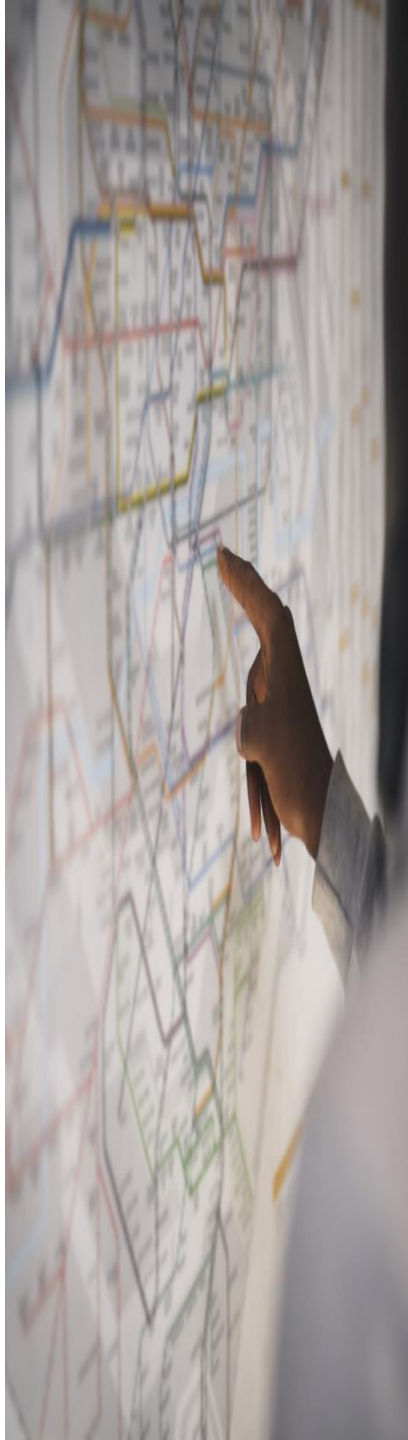
Relational

Ideological.



Material power

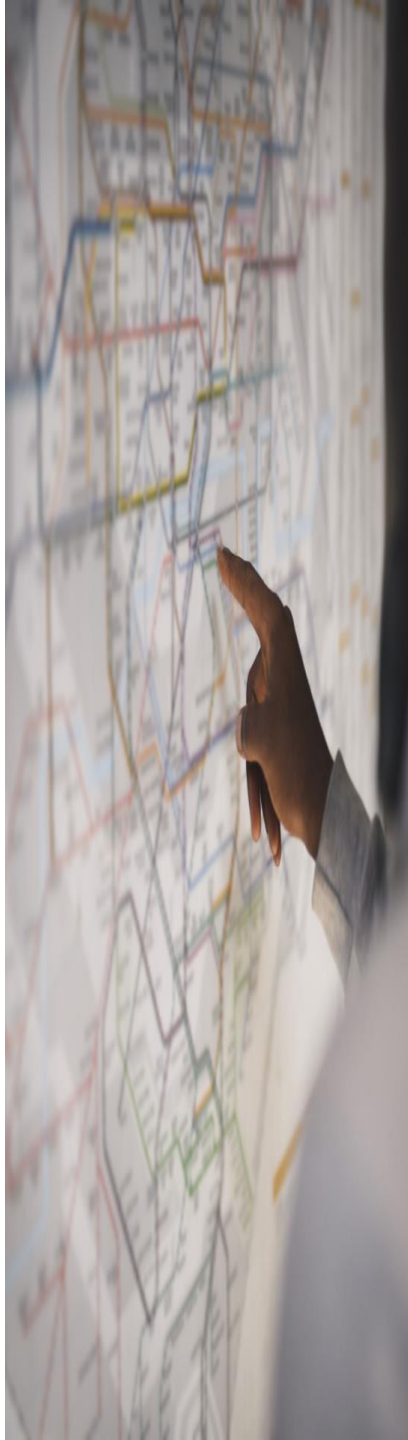
Material power is the traditional understanding that sees power as a **material capability** or **resource**, **something** that is **possessed**, such as **nuclear weapons**, that allows one geopolitical actor(Nation) to **exercise power over another**.



Relational power

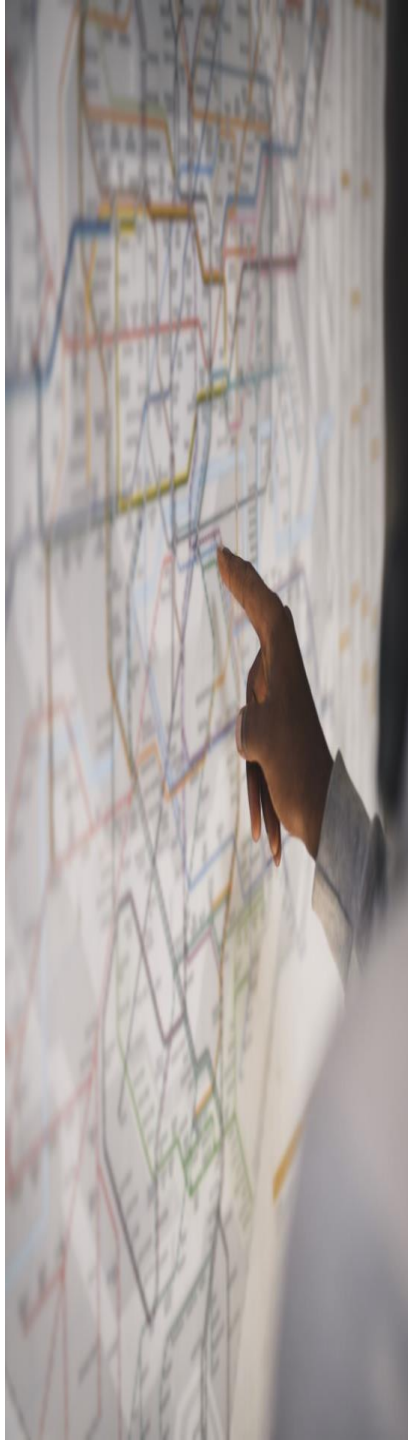
Relational power builds upon the **idea of material power** but is critical of seeing **power** as a "**thing**." A relational sense of power argues that material capabilities only have an **effect when two actors form a power relation**.

In other words, **strong requires weak**, or **dominant requires control**.



Ideological power

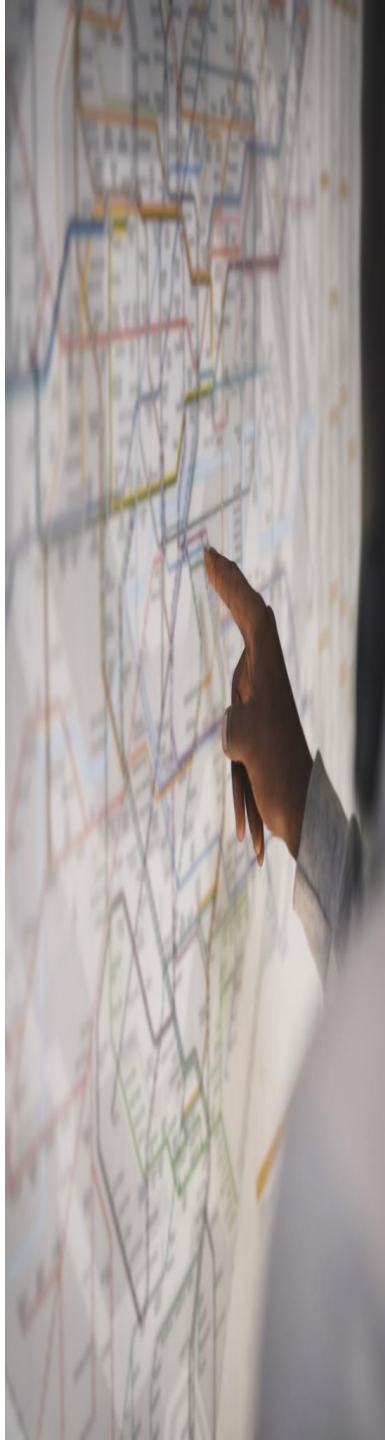
Ideological power is the **ability** to make others do **what you want them to do willingly without considering alternatives**. Certain actions become seen as **normal** or **natural** when they are in fact preserving certain power relations and dismissing alternative relations.




Mediterranean Sea
Baghdad
Tehran
Kabul
AFGHANISTAN
IRAQ
Amman
IRAN
JORDAN
Cairo
Kuwait City
KUWAIT
Persian Gulf
PAKISTAN
BAHRAIN
EGYPT
Al Manamah
Doha
Abu Dhabi
Riyadh
Gulf of Oman
QATAR
UAE
Muscat
SAUDI ARABIA
Red Sea
OMAN
NORTH YEMEN
SOUTH YEMEN
Khartoum
San'a'
Gulf of Aden
Arabian Sea
SUDAN
Djibouti
Aden
DJIBOUTI
Addis Ababa
ETHIOPIA
SOMALIA
Mogadishu
KENYA
Nairobi

Box 1.4

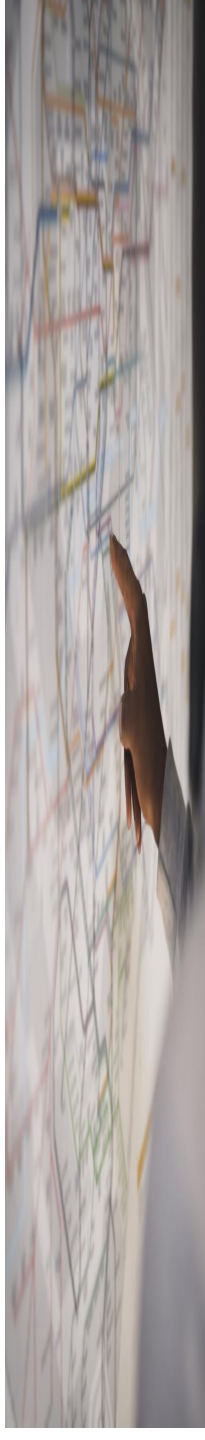
Global commodity chains



Box 1.4 Recap: Global commodity chains

Global commodity chains (**GCCs**) **link** together the **production** and **supply of raw materials**, the **processing** of these materials, the **production** of **components**, the **assembly of finished products**, and the **distribution**, **sales** and **consumption** of these products.

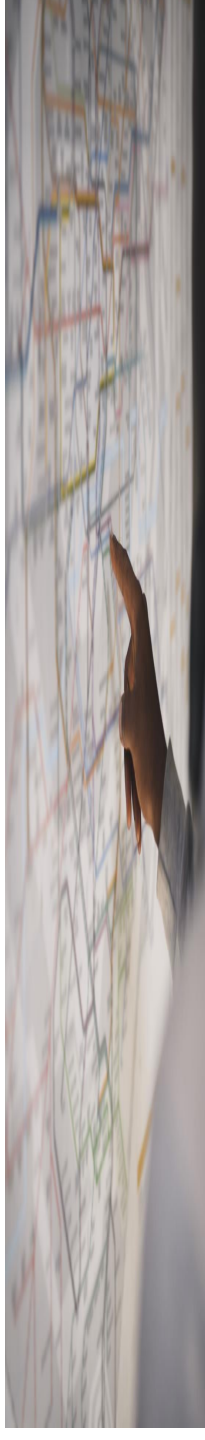
For example, **farmers**, **mining** or **plantation companies**, **component suppliers**, **manufacturers**, **subcontractors**, **transport operators**, **distributors**, **retailers** and **consumers**.



Box 1.4 Recap: Global commodity chains

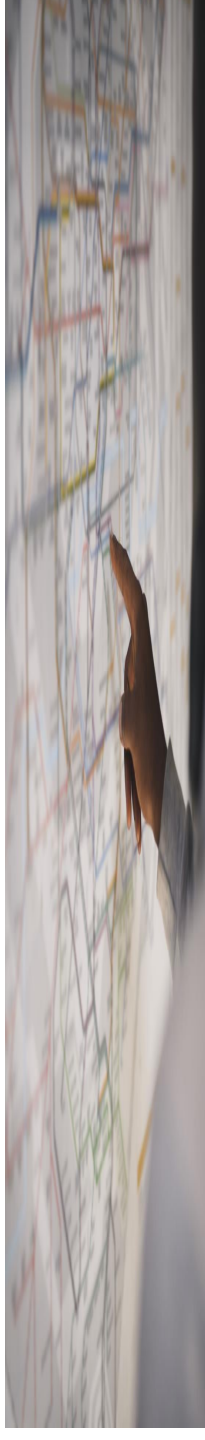
Global commodity chains have distinct geography, linking together different **stages** of **production** carried out in **different places**.

Some parts of the **production process add more value** or **profit**, **creating tensions** between the different participants in the **supply chain** over who captures this value.



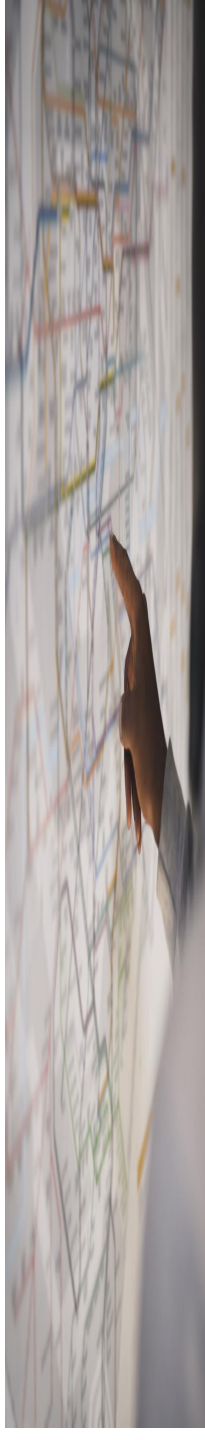
Box 1.4 Recap: Example

Production and **consumption** of **particular commodities** help us to **trace** and **uncover economic connections** between **places**, **linking** different **localities** to **global trading networks** and showing how the range of goods (**such as milk**) that **we consume on a daily basis** are **produced**, **distributed** and **sold**.



Box 1.6 Recap

fictitious commodities



Box 1.6: Fictitious commodities

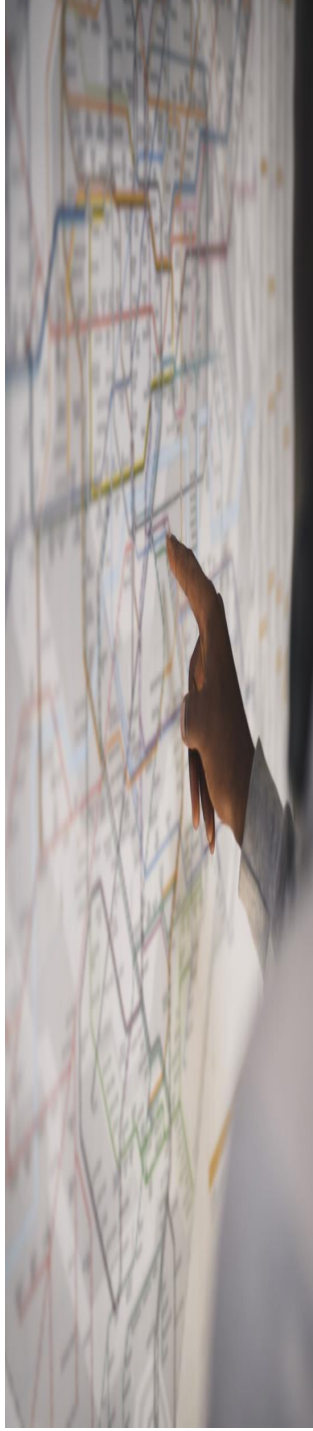


Polanyi's broad conception of the economy and his insights into the underlying nature of market society has come to inform debates about contemporary processes of globalisation and the social 'embeddedness' of the economy.

Box 1.6: Fictitious commodities

In **The Great Transformation**, published in 1944, **Polanyi** explores the origins and development of market society during the nineteenth century. Arguing that **land**, **labour**, and **money** are **not true commodities**.

Polanyi identified **land**, **labour** and **money** as '**fictitious commodities**' because they are **not actually produced for sale** on the market like true **commodities**.



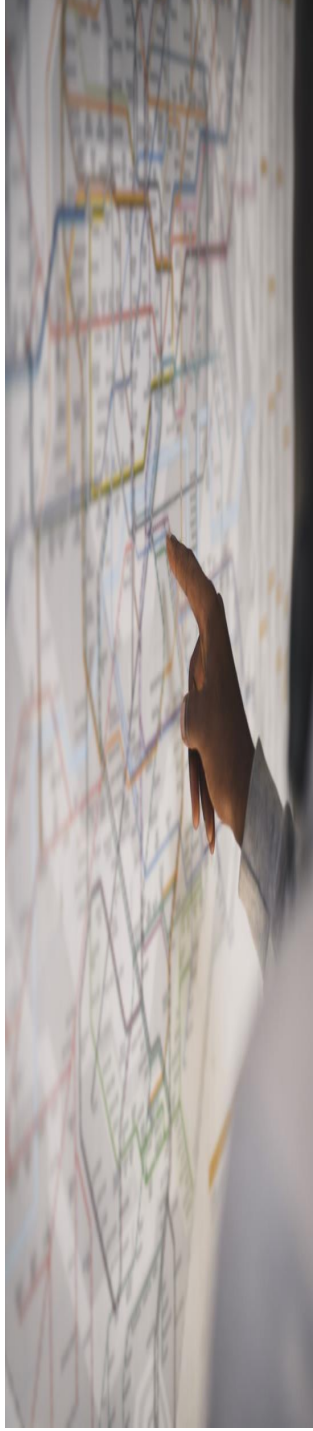
Polanyi's Assumptions

Polanyi begins by outlining what exactly a "**self-regulating market**" means. A self-regulating market economy is one in which the **entire system** is controlled through the **workings (Forces) of the market**.

Some **assumptions** must be held in order to support:-

First, it must be assumed that **human beings** always behave in ways that are **economically advantageous**.

Second, The **same good** at **two different prices**.



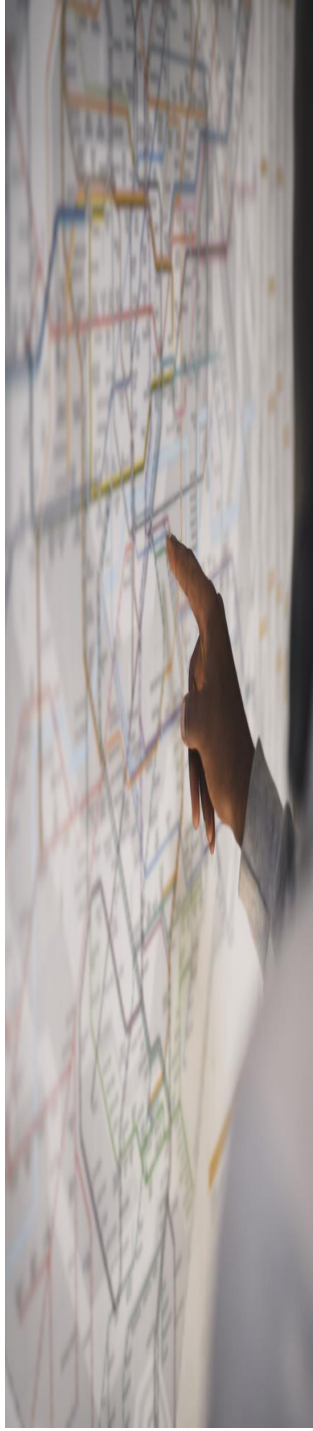
Polanyi's Assumptions

Third, **Customers** will **purchase** the goods at a **lower cost.**

Fourth, the **supply of goods** and **services** at a **price** is equal to the **demand** at that **price**.

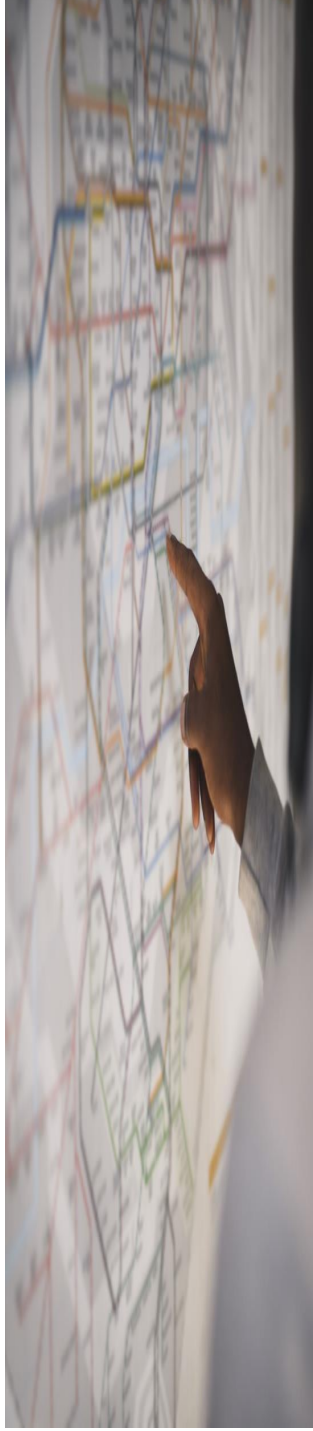
Fifth, the **production of goods** and **services** is determined by **price alone**.

Laissez-faire



What is Laissez-faire?

Laissez-faire is a policy of minimum governmental interference in the economic affairs of **individuals** and **society**. The doctrine of **laissez-faire** is usually associated with **economists**.

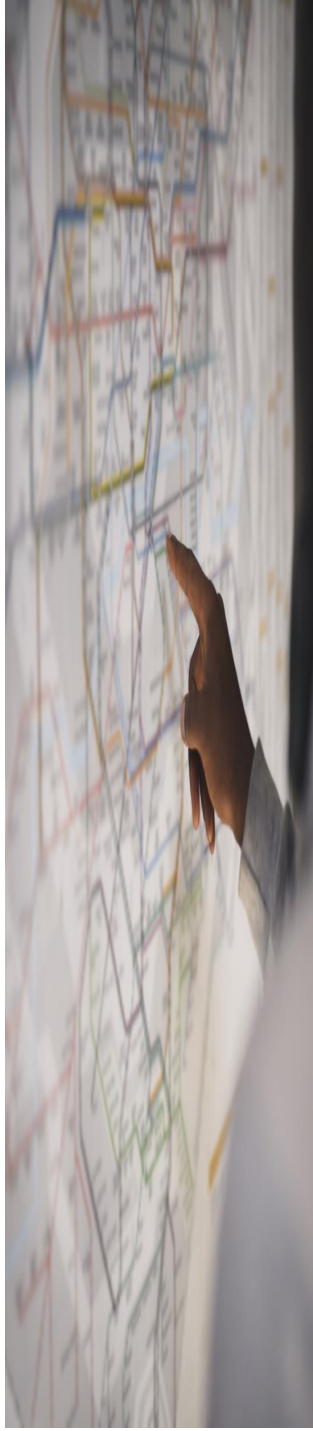


Polanyi's Assumptions

Polanyi points out, "**Self-regulation implies that all production is for sale on the market** and that **all incomes derive from such sales**"

The **Land**, **Labour**, and **Money** are, therefore, **traded on the market** whose prices are represented by the "**commodity prices**, **wages**, **rent**, and **interest**"

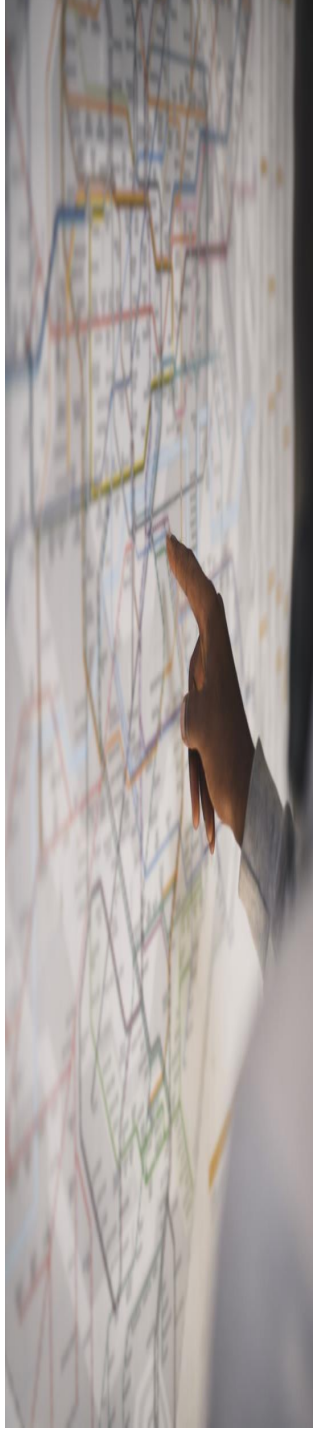
To understand the **land**, **labour**, and **money** as **fictitious commodities** in today's market system.



Polanyi's Conclusion

Even though they are **bought** and **sold**, they **are not produced specifically for sale**. Because the **land is simply nature**; **labour is just human life**; **money is merely a purchasing power**.

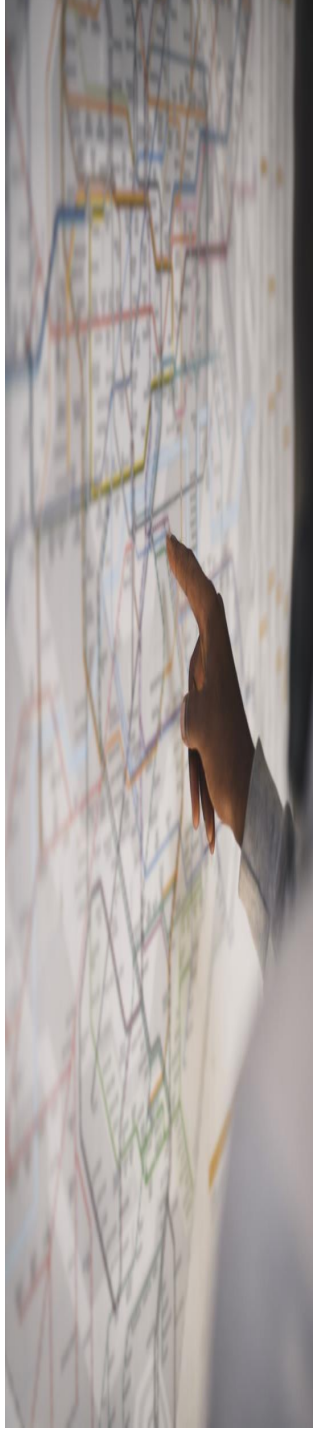
He, therefore, refers to these as "**fictitious**" because **they have no basis in production** or **sale** other than their **ability** to be **sold** on the **market**. Finally, Polanyi concludes that the market system itself is artificial because of buying and selling.



Box 1.6: The institution process

The identification of these **fictitious commodities** is important to **Polanyi's argument**, indicating that a pure **self-regulating market economy is impossible** since **state intervention is required to match Supply** and **Demand** for:-

I. **Land**
II. **Labour**
III. **Money**



Box 1.6: The institution process

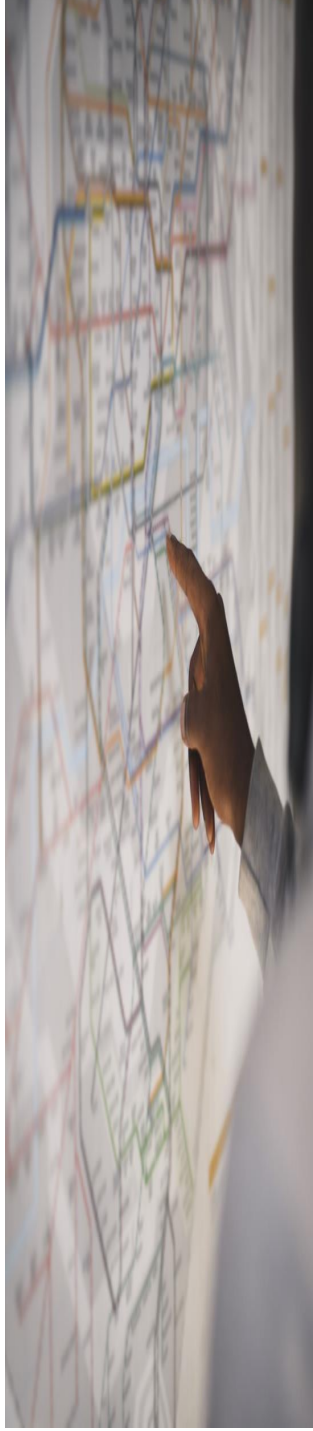
He demonstrates **how the construction of competitive markets depended upon state action** through:-

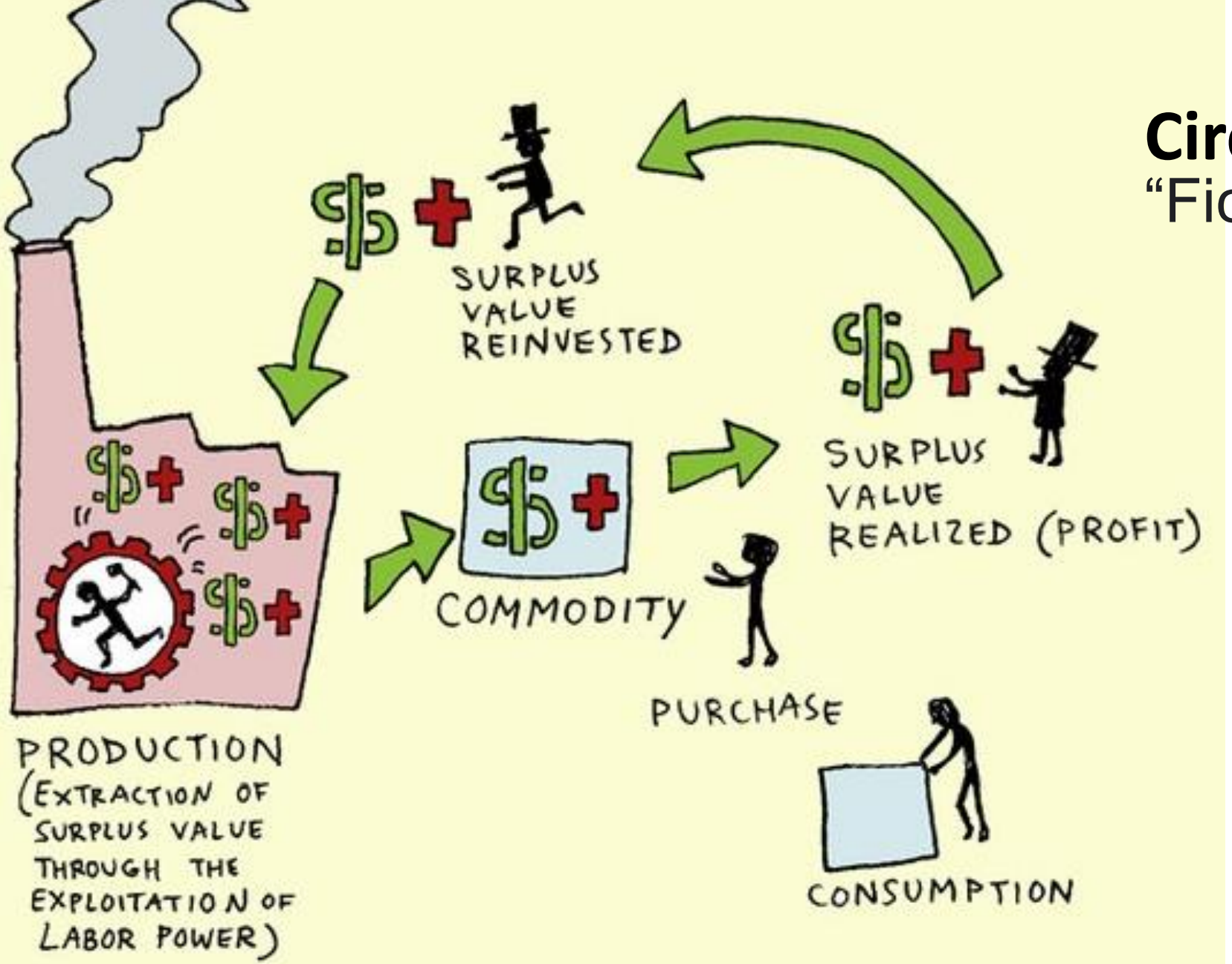
I. **Property rights and contracts.**

II. **Labour legislation.**

III. **Measures to ensure a stable food supply.**

IV. **Regulation of the banking system.**





Circuit of Capital

"Fictitious Commodities"

- **Land**
- **Money**
- **Labor**

Any Questions?



Thank You